

Christopher Hamm

Director of Technology

Platform & Engineering Leader

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Louisville, KY Area

Summary

Technology executive with 20+ years leading development strategy, platform architecture, and engineering teams for customer-facing digital platforms serving 100M+ monthly unique visitors, including CNET, ZDNET, PCMag, and IGN. Delivered platform and commerce features that generated $5.0M in additional revenue, led engineering through two acquisitions, and moved a flagship CMS to WordPress without a data cutover.

Currently focused on applied AI in engineering: built an enterprise generative-AI development framework around Spec-Driven Development, helped design an AI-enabled delivery workflow adopted as a division standard, and shaped a RAG-based conversational product search on Gemini and Vertex AI Search.

A working technologist who still ships production code across CMS, catalog APIs, data pipelines, and commerce systems, with deep experience in vendor and budget ownership and in PCI and SOX controls.

I also volunteer as a mentor for transitioning military veterans and military spouses through American Corporate Partners (ACP).

Work Experience

Director of Software Engineering at Ziff Davis

Sept 2024 - Oct 2026 · Remote

- Owned the technology strategy and roadmap for the catalog platform behind CNET, ZDNET, PCMag, Mashable, Popular Science, IGN, and RetailMeNot, unifying product data, APIs, ingestion, and commerce across divisions into a single source of truth.
- Shaped the design of a RAG product search system on Gemini and Vertex AI Search, supporting conversational and standard search; built its proxy and caching layer, raising throughput from about 5 to 100+ requests per second, and set up its test plans and QA.
- Built an enterprise generative-AI development framework around Spec-Driven Development, and helped design an AI-enabled delivery workflow connecting Jira and GitHub to an AI agent that became the division standard, measured with a DORA-based dashboard.
- Led the CMS transition from a custom platform to WordPress with partner XWP, using an API that shared databases with the legacy CMS so editors could move without a data cutover.
- Refocused engineering priorities toward conversion- and revenue-centric architecture, protecting performance baselines while supporting recurring commerce revenue.
- Built Python data ingestion and processing for 30K+ merchants, and partnered with data science on coupon and best-offer models.
- Directed the Salesforce integration into an ad media planning tool, and maintained PCI and SOX controls for subscription systems.
- Managed multiple engineering managers while regularly shipping production code for catalog APIs, ETL pipelines, and commerce integrations.

Director of Software Engineering at Red Ventures

Aug 2021 - Sept 2024 · Remote

- Delivered next-generation platform and commerce features that generated an additional $5.0M in revenue.
- Directed backend platforms for content and catalog APIs, knowledge management, and advertising and commerce revenue systems, serving 360+ internal users publishing 25K+ pieces a year to 100M+ monthly uniques.
- Led the engineering division through its acquisition by Ziff Davis, coordinating technical due diligence, data transitions, and system transfers without interrupting consumer-facing platforms.

- Managed concurrent brand divestments, platform operations, and feature roadmaps; partnered with product leadership to set KPIs and ROI targets for every initiative.
- Grew engineers from mid-level to senior through structured mentorship and opportunity matching.

Senior Engineering Manager, CNET Media Group at Red Ventures
Oct 2020 - Aug 2021

- Managed major technology transitions after Red Ventures acquired the division from ViacomCBS, while hiring senior and mid-level engineers.

Senior Engineering Manager, CNET Media Group at CBS Interactive
Oct 2018 - Oct 2020 · Louisville, KY Area

- Owned backend CMS and API engineering for CNET.com, TVGuide.com, TechRepublic.com, ZDNet.com, and Download.com.
- Led a distributed, multi-timezone agile team of up to 10 direct reports across cloud migrations, CMS platform work, and feature development.
- Managed critical vendor relationships end to end, including renewals, budget justifications, negotiations, and accountability for service quality and ROI.
- Developed a QA process using an image recognition model (later YOLO, with built-in retraining) to detect broken web pages.

Software Engineering Manager at CBS Interactive
Jan 2012 - Oct 2018

- Managed application engineering and site development for CNET.com with 6 engineers plus international contractors; technical authority for ads, lead generation, and conversion tracking.
- Instituted automated build pipelines, mandatory code reviews, application security hardening, and monitoring for major traffic events such as CES.
- Established developer capacity models that improved estimation and delivery predictability.

Earlier Career: CBS Interactive & University of Louisville
2003 - 2012

- **Lead Web Developer, CBS Interactive (2010 - 2012):** delivered web initiatives valued at $4.0M+ on schedule with a team of 3, and architected the patented asynchronous page-updating system used across CNET.com, CBSNews.com, and Download.com.
- **Senior Web Developer, CBS Interactive (2006 - 2010):** built Java, Spring, and JavaScript applications for CNET.com, CBSNews.com, and Download.com; received the CBS Interactive Engineer's Award (Q3 2007).
- **R&D Systems Analyst, University of Louisville iTRC (2003 - 2006):** supported a Homeland Security-funded communications R&D project and incubation data center under FIPS and NIST standards.

Military Service: Indiana Army National Guard
May 1999 - May 2006

- Infantry Soldier, then Military Police; attended Officer Leadership Training.
- Honorably discharged as a Specialist (E-4); received the Army Achievement Medal and service ribbons.

Key Skills

Leadership & Strategy

Technology Strategy & Roadmaps	Agile Team Leadership	Hiring
Vendor & Agency Governance	Stakeholder Alignment	
Budget & Capital Planning	Leadership Development	

Architecture & Platforms

CMS Migration	REST APIs	Incident Response & SLAs
Headless / API-First	DevOps	Security
CRM & Commerce Integration	Release Management	

AI

AI-Augmented Development	RAG	Conversational Search
Spec-Driven Development	Vertex AI Search, Gemini	Image Recognition, YOLO

Data & Cloud

AWS, GCP	ETL Pipelines	Kafka, Confluent
BigQuery, Looker	MongoDB, DocumentDB	Databricks, Snowflake

Governance & Compliance

IT Governance	PCI Audit Controls	Data Privacy Governance
Technology Risk Management	SOX Controls	FIPS, NIST

Languages & Frameworks

Java, Go, Python	Spring Framework	Salesforce
SQL, JavaScript, Node.js	WordPress	

Education

Indiana University

2000 - 2005

BS, Computer Science & Business

Certifications

Google Cloud Certified – Cloud Digital Leader

Google Cloud

Patents

US Patent 9,805,135: Systems and methods for updating rich internet applications

Filed Mar 2011 · Granted Oct 2017 · Assigned to CBS Interactive

- A pre-framework reactive UI architecture enabling partial page updates without full reloads, paralleling SPA patterns later standardized by Angular, React, and Vue.
- Structured server responses map discrete payload segments to client-side page regions, with automatic UI synchronization and server-triggered side effects such as ad activation.
- Declarative update rules can be stored, fetched dynamically, and reused across pages.

See patent